



Between the time I wrote this book and the day it went into production, the landscape of U.S. politics was radically altered with the presidential defeat on November 8, 2016, of former secretary of state Hillary Clinton by Donald Trump. Within days, media pundits and pollsters were trying to make sense of the upset, the surprise win by Trump, particularly since Clinton won the popular vote by close to three million votes.

Immediately, there were claims that “fake news” circulating online was responsible for the outcome. Indeed, as I gave talks about this book in the weeks after the election, I could only note in my many public talks that “as I’ve argued for years about the harm toward women and girls through commercial information bias circulating through platforms like Google, no one has seemed to care until it threw a presidential election.” Notably, one remarkable story about disinformation (patently false information intended to deceive) made headlines about the election results.

This new political landscape has dramatically altered the way we might think about public institutions being a major force in leveling the playing field of information that is curated in the public interest. And it will likely be the source of a future book that recontextualizes what information means in the new policy regime that ensues under the leadership of avowed White supremacists and disinformation experts who have entered the highest levels of public governance.

Agencies that could have played a meaningful role in supporting research about the role of information and research in society, including the Institute for Museum and Library Services, the National Endowment for the Humanities, and the National Endowment for the Arts, are all under the threat of being permanently defunded and dismantled as of the moment this book goes into production. In fact, public research universities are also facing serious threats in cuts to federal funding because of their lack of compliance with the new administration’s policies. This has

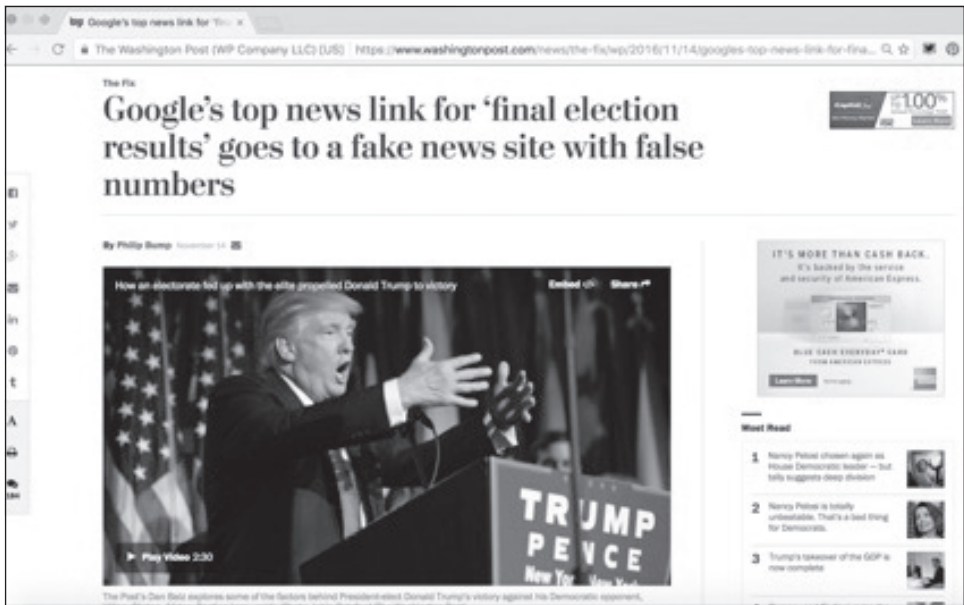


Figure E.1. Google search for “final election results” leads to fake news. Source: *Washington Post*, November 14, 2016.



Figure E.2. Google results on final election results incorrectly show Trump as the winner of the popular vote. Source: *Washington Post*, November 14, 2016.

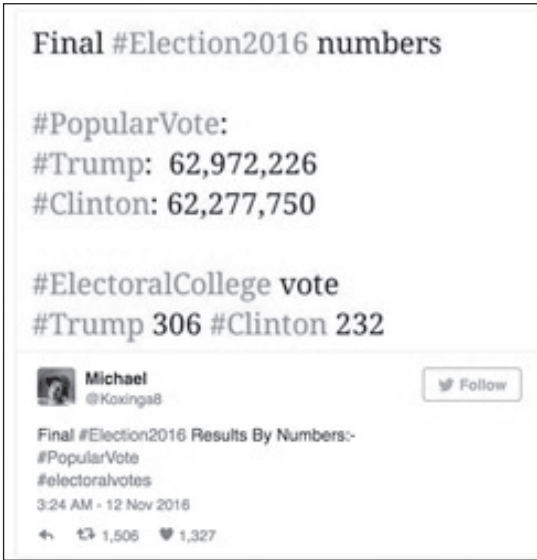


Figure E.3. Circulation of false information on Twitter shows Trump as the winner of the popular vote, November 14, 2016.

so radically altered the research landscape to the political right that scientists and researchers marched on Washington, D.C., on April 22, 2017, in response to orders that government-funded scientists and researchers stop conducting and disseminating research to the public. The potential for such a precedent may extend to public research universities, or at least many faculty members are working under the premise that this may not be out of the realm of possibility over the next four to eight years.

In this book, I have argued that the neoliberal political and economic environment has profited tremendously from misinformation and mischaracterization of communities, with a range of consequences for the most disenfranchised and marginalized among us. I have also argued for increased nonprofit and public research funding to explore alternatives to commercial information platforms, which would have included support of noncommercial search engines that could serve the public and pay closer attention to the circulation of patently false or harmful information. In the current environment, I would be remiss if I did not acknowledge, on the eve of the publication of this book, that this may not be viable at all given the current policy environment that is unfolding.

My hope is that the public will reclaim its institutions and direct our resources in service of a multiracial democracy. Now, more than ever, we need libraries, universities, schools, and information resources that will help bolster and further expand democracy for all, rather than shrink the landscape of participation along racial, religious, and gendered lines. Information circulates in cultural contexts of acceptability. It is not enough to simply want the most accurate and credible information to rise to the top of a search engine, but it is certainly an important step toward impacting the broader culture of information use that helps us make decisions about the distribution of resources among the most powerful and the most disenfranchised members of our society.

In short, we must fight to suspend the circulation of racist and sexist material that is used to erode our civil and human rights. I hope this book provides some steps toward doing so.